

IMWIRSA

International Maritime Welfare Innovation Research and Support Association

SHIP VISITOR HANDBOOK

A CONCISE GUIDE TO SHIP VISITING

Code of Conduct and practical guide for volunteers and coordinators of the IMWIRSA seafarer support programme

Developed by

an international team of specialists as part of expert and methodological work drawing on many years of practical experience in seafarer welfare, ship visiting, and port welfare programmes. The methodology draws on seafarer surveys conducted by volunteers over several years, and was prepared with the expert and methodological support of maritime scholars and practitioners who form the IMWIRSA Scientific-Coordination Advisory Council.

Document status: educational and methodological guide for IMWIRSA volunteers and coordinators.

This is not a statutory legal instrument; binding requirements are set by applicable national law and the international conventions listed in “Sources”.

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PART I. CODE OF CONDUCT FOR SHIP VISITORS

Participant of the IMWIRSA seafarer support programme

1. General Provisions

1.1.

This Code sets out the ethical, professional, and behavioural principles binding on all ship visitors acting within the IMWIRSA seafarer support programme (International Maritime Welfare Innovation Research and Support Association).

1.2. A ship visitor

— is a trained representative of the IMWIRSA programme who visits merchant ships to provide social, moral, informational and, where appropriate, spiritual support to crew members. A ship visitor does not make managerial, commercial, or operational decisions and may not be regarded as a person influencing the operations of the ship, the crew, the shipowner, or the agent.

1.3. A ship visitor is not:

- an inspector,
- a representative of the shipowner,
- an agent,
- a medical professional,
- a lawyer,
- a trade union representative.

1.4. A ship visitor's activity is carried out:

- on a voluntary or contractual basis;
- with regard to the applicable provisions of the Maritime Labour Convention, 2006, as amended (MLC, 2006), and, when visiting fishing vessels, ILO Convention No. 188 (C188);
- in compliance with the national law of the port country and applicable port regulations.

1.5.

Compliance with this Code is a mandatory condition for acting as a ship visitor within the IMWIRSA programme.

2. Core Principles of a Ship Visitor's Work

A ship visitor is guided by the following principles:

2.1. *Respect for Human Dignity*

Every seafarer is treated as an individual, regardless of:

- nationality,
- religion,
- culture,
- gender,
- rank,
- shipping company.

2.2. Neutrality and Independence

A visitor remains neutral on matters of:

- politics,
- commercial interests,
- internal crew conflicts,
- labour disputes.

Neutrality means objectivity and independence from the parties to a conflict — not inaction: a visitor does not take sides, but is required to record a signal of a violation and refer the seafarer to a competent body (the IMWIRSA coordinator, the ITF, port or state authorities).

2.3. Voluntary Engagement

Any interaction with a seafarer is entirely voluntary and may be ended at the seafarer's wish at any time.

2.4. Confidentiality

Information obtained during a visit is not disclosed, except in cases of:

- a direct threat to the seafarer's life or health;
- the need to pass information to the programme coordinator in order to provide assistance.

A visitor does not conduct an investigation or demand evidence, but may, with the seafarer's consent, accept and safely pass on voluntarily provided information to a competent specialist. Information is recorded in anonymised form unless the protection of life requires otherwise.

2.5. Professional Boundaries

A visitor is aware of the limits of their role and does not exceed the authority granted to them.

3. Duties of a Ship Visitor

A ship visitor is required to:

3.1. Comply with:

- this Code;
- port security regulations;
- the ship's requirements and the crew's instructions.

3.2. Introduce themselves when visiting:

- correctly,
- honestly,
- stating their affiliation with the IMWIRSA programme.

3.3. Demonstrate:

- courtesy,
- tact,
- restraint,
- respect for shipboard hierarchy.

3.4. Not interfere:

- in operational processes;
- in disciplinary procedures on board;

- in the management decisions of the master and officers.

3.5. Report identified problems:

- to the IMWIRSA coordinator;
- only to the extent necessary to provide assistance.

3.6. Maintain the required reporting on the outcome of each visit.

4. Prohibitions and Restrictions

A ship visitor is prohibited from:

4.1. Providing:

- legal,
- medical,
- financial advice.

4.2. Promising help or solutions

that fall outside what the IMWIRSA programme is able to deliver.

4.3. Accepting or handing over:

- money,
- documents,
- seafarers' personal belongings “for safekeeping”.

4.4. Taking photographs or video

without the separate consent of every person recognisable in the image, and without the ship's permission and compliance with port rules. Permission from the crew in general does not substitute for the consent of the specific person whose face would be recognisable in the photograph.

4.5. Entering into:

- personal,
- dependent,
- romantic relationships with seafarers.

4.6. Criticising:

- the shipowner,
- the master,
- a seafarer's nationality,
- religion,
- or culture.

4.7. Visiting a ship:

- while fatigued,
- while ill,
- under the influence of alcohol or other intoxicants.

5. Working with Vulnerable and Crisis Situations

5.1. On identifying signs of:

- emotional crisis,
- violence,
- harassment,
- a threat to life,

a visitor is required to:

- remain calm;
- not leave the situation unattended;
- inform the programme coordinator immediately.

5.2. A visitor is not entitled to:

- conduct an investigation;
- assess guilt;
- take on the role of a psychologist or rescuer.

5.3. The visitor's core task

— is to recognise the signal, provide support, and pass on the information through the established route.

- a visitor does not resolve the crisis;
- a visitor recognises → refers → accompanies.

6. Consequences of Breaching the Code

6.1. A breach of this Code may result in:

- temporary suspension from visits;
- withdrawal of ship visitor status;
- termination of cooperation with the IMWIRSA programme.

6.2.

Decisions are made by the programme coordinator and/or the IMWIRSA Scientific-Coordination Advisory Council (SCBT).

7. Final Provisions

7.1.

This Code is binding on all ship visitors acting within the IMWIRSA programme.

7.2. A ship visitor confirms they have read the Code by:

- signature;
- or electronic confirmation (for remote training).

Note

Detailed guidance, visit procedures, and practical scenarios are set out in the IMWIRSA Ship Visitor Handbook, which is used together with this Code.

PART II. SHIP VISITOR HANDBOOK

Section 1. Who a Ship Visitor Is, and Why the Role Exists

1.1. The Visitor's Role

A ship visitor is a trained volunteer or staff member who visits the crews of merchant ships to provide moral, social, and spiritual support. They are not an inspector, agent, doctor, or trade union representative, but can help put a seafarer in touch with the right services.

A ship visitor acts solely within a humanitarian, social, and informational mission. They do not take part in running the ship, do not interfere in commercial, operational, disciplinary, or legal matters, and do not make decisions that fall within the competence of the master, shipowner, agent, or port authorities.

A ship visitor is a “friendly face on board” — a link between the ship and the shore.

1.2. Main Aims of a Visit:

- Supporting seafarers' psycho-emotional wellbeing.
- Providing information on rights and opportunities for rest and leisure.
- Providing access to help where crew rights have been violated.
- Helping with family contact and spiritual support.

1.3. What a Visitor Does:

- Greets the crew and briefly introduces themselves.
- Offers help, leaflets, and the seafarers' centre's contact details.
- Listens attentively, without making promises they cannot keep.
- Assesses the situation (mood, needs, how open the crew is).
- Passes information to the coordinator or specialists where necessary.

1.4. What a Visitor Does NOT Do:

- Does not interfere in the ship's working processes.
- Does not provide legal, medical, or financial advice, and does not interpret points of law or medicine.
- Does not provide material assistance from personal funds and does not accept money from seafarers.
- Does not take photographs without permission.
- Does not promise help unless certain it can be delivered.

Section 2. Preparing for a Ship Visit

2.1. Preparation Before Heading to the Port

A visitor must understand in advance the limits of their competence and must not go beyond what is set out in the Ship Visitor Code and the rules of the IMWIRSA programme. Any non-standard situations, requests, or risk signals are to be referred to the programme coordinator and are not resolved by the visitor independently.

Before heading to a ship, a visitor should be:

- Informed — aware of the ship's type, flag, company, and crew composition.
- Prepared — carrying everything needed.
- Ready — prepared for a range of scenarios, from a polite refusal to an emotional conversation.

Mini Checklist Before a Visit:

- Port or centre-issued pass / identification.

- The centre's contact details.
- Business cards, leaflets.
- A list of current events, available services, Wi-Fi, transfer options, etc.
- The volunteer phone issued by IMWIRSA, fully charged.
- Personal protective equipment (per port rules).
- A vest with visitor markings.
- A notebook / form for recording the outcome of the visit.
- A small bag or backpack with any useful items to leave behind.

2.2. What Is Useful to Know About the Ship

Ask the coordinator, or check in advance:

- The ship's name and IMO number.
- The ship's type (container ship, tanker, bulk carrier, ferry, cruise ship, etc.).
- The crew's national composition.
- Any known issues on board (e.g. shore leave denied, wages delayed, crew change under way).
- Whether this is the ship's first visit in this port or it has interacted with visitors before.
- Any current health restrictions or quarantine measures.

Conduct and Dress Code

- Clothing should be neat, comfortable, and modest — not attention-drawing.
- A visitor must always comply with port and ship rules.
- On boarding, greet the officer on watch and explain the purpose of the visit.
- Always be courteous, composed, and friendly.
- Do not be pushy — if it is made clear that the crew does not want to talk, respect that.

2.3. After the Visit — Reporting

On returning to the centre or headquarters, the visitor completes a short form:

Sample Report Form:

- Date of visit: _____
- Ship name: _____
- Ship type: _____
- Crew size: _____
- National composition (in aggregate form only, and only where necessary for welfare-support planning; no names or other identifying details): _____
- Any materials handed out: _____
- Overall outcome of the visit: _____

This form is a general visit report and must not contain names, personal details, or information that could identify a specific individual. If the visit gave rise to a separate case requiring assistance (a complaint, a request for support, signs of a rights violation, or another sensitive situation), it is not recorded on this form. Important: if you learn of a serious problem (emotional distress, a rights violation, a request for help) — do not attempt to act on your own, and do not record the details on this form. Such cases are handled separately — through a Confidential Case Report, stating the legal basis for processing the data (see Section 9) and with access limited to those directly involved. Contact the IMWIRSA coordinator for the form and the procedure for completing it.

Section 3. How a Visit Unfolds: Stages, Communication, Typical Scenarios

3.1. Stages of a Ship Visit

A ship visit can be broken down into four broad stages:

Stage 1. Approaching the Ship and Greeting

What to do:

- Approach the gangway and greet the officer on watch (usually the third officer or an able seaman).
- Introduce yourself briefly: “Hello! My name is [Name], I’m a ship visitor from IMWIRSA. May I come on board to say hello to the crew?”
- If refused — thank them and leave calmly.
- If the visit is permitted — sign the log, if required.

Worth remembering:

- First impressions matter a great deal.
- A calm, confident tone is the key to a successful start.

Stage 2. First Contact with the Crew

Goal: create a trusting, friendly atmosphere.

Suggested questions:

- “How are you today?”
- “When did you arrive in port?”
- “Do you have permission to go ashore?”
- “Have you been to our seafarers’ centre before?”

Use greetings in the seafarers' native language wherever you can.

Important:

- Do not open with difficult topics.
- Do not have the conversation in front of senior officers if there is visible tension.

Stage 3. Main Interaction

What you can offer:

- Information about the seafarers' centre.
- Wi-Fi, transfer, leisure options, help buying a SIM card, city maps.
- The chance to pass on a prayer request to the religious or spiritual service of the seafarer's own choosing.
- If the duty officer has given permission — leaving a flyer, leaflet, contact details, or gifts from donors on board.

Common situations:

- Seafarers complaining of loneliness or fatigue.
- A seafarer with no contact with their family.
- A seafarer in port for the first time who doesn't know what's available ashore.
- The master refusing to allow shore leave.

Important: a visitor does not judge whether the master's or the shipowner's actions are lawful, and does not draw conclusions about violations. Their task is to record the request, provide information about possible sources of help, and pass the information to the IMWIRSA coordinator.

How to respond:

- Listen without interrupting.
- Do not promise what you cannot guarantee.
- Where necessary — pass the information to the programme coordinator.

Stage 4. Ending the Visit

- Thank the crew for their hospitality.
- Ask whether anything needs to be taken ashore.
- Say goodbye in person, where possible.
- Leave, and sign the log if required.

3.2. Communication Guidelines

- Speak simply and clearly, bearing in mind that English may not be the crew's first language.
- A smile and eye contact matter.
- Try not to interrupt — let the seafarer speak.
- Respect boundaries and confidentiality.
- Do not ask directly about wages, religion, or personal relationships.

3.3. Typical Scenarios and Response Patterns

Scenario 1: A seafarer cannot reach their family

Visitor's response:

- Ask whether they have Wi-Fi access.
- Offer help arranging a transfer to the centre, or a SIM card.
- Note the request if technical support is needed.

Scenario 2: A seafarer says they are not being paid

Visitor's response:

- Do not react with shock.
- Ask: “Would you like someone to follow up?”
- Explain that you are not a lawyer, but can pass the information to the IMWIRSA coordinator.

Scenario 3: A visitor senses that a seafarer is distressed

Visitor's response:

- Ask whether everything is all right.
- Offer support: “It's okay to feel low sometimes, you're not alone.”
- Offer to talk, if they want to.
- Don't press — but offer the seafarers' centre's contact details.

A visitor does not carry out investigations, does not gather evidence, and does not act as a mediator between parties to a conflict. In crisis situations, a visitor's actions are limited to initial contact, ensuring safety, and passing information to the authorised persons.

3.4. What to Do If a Situation Goes Beyond the Visitor's Role

- If there is a threat to life or health, pass the information to the senior visitor or coordinator immediately.
- Never promise to “fix everything”.
- Never interfere in command relationships or working processes.

Section 4. Special Categories of Seafarers and Signs of Stress: Recognising Them Without Doing Harm

The visitor's core task is to be attentive, observant, and sensitive — without being intrusive.

Not every seafarer will open up at the first meeting, especially where internal tension, depression, or an on-board conflict is involved. Even so, a visitor can play a key role simply by being an attentive, humane presence to talk to.

4.1. Vulnerable Categories of Seafarers

Some groups of seafarers face isolation, discrimination, or stress more often than others:

Young / early-career seafarers

Uncertainty, pressure from senior crew, first voyages, fear of making mistakes.

Women on board

May be the only woman on board, and can face isolation, possible discrimination, or harassment.

Seafarers from lower-income countries

Often afraid to complain, and tolerate breaches of working conditions and pay.

Seafarers on solo contracts (with no acquaintances aboard)

A heightened level of loneliness, especially on long voyages.

Seafarers who have recently lost a loved one or been through a crisis

Their emotional state may be unstable even where this is not outwardly visible.

4.2. Signs of Emotional and Psychosocial Strain

A seafarer will sometimes not say it directly, but behaviour and expression can reveal a great deal. Watch for:

- Withdrawal, avoiding conversation, an “everything's fine” answer with no detail.
- A lowered tone of voice, no smile.
- Complaints of poor sleep, fatigue, no wish to go ashore.
- Recurring phrases such as “just one more month”, “nearly there”, “no time to rest”.
- Anxiety, irritability, frequently looking around, a tense posture.
- A seafarer reluctant to return to the ship — a sign of burnout.

4.3. How a Visitor Can Respond Appropriately

What you can do:

- Listen carefully, without interrupting.
- Ask open questions: “How's the voyage going?”, “How long have you been at sea?”, “Do you get a chance to rest between voyages?”

Respond calmly and with empathy:

“That sounds hard, I understand. You're not alone — we're here to support you.”

- Suggest visiting the seafarers' centre.
- Say that the conversation can continue another time.

What not to do:

- Diagnose: “Oh, you're depressed.”

- Push help on someone: “You really need to talk to a psychologist.”
- Promise the impossible: “We’ll fix your problem.”
- Press religious or cultural topics uninvited.

4.4. Support Without Intrusion

Sometimes it is enough simply to be there. A ship visitor is not a psychotherapist, but can:

- Show the seafarer that they are seen and heard.
- Remind them that there is somewhere they can rest and feel like themselves again.
- Provide contact details for a support service, religious mission, or help centre, where appropriate.

Practical note. A gentle way to offer help:

“Sometimes talking helps. If you ever feel like you want to share something, I’m here, or someone from the centre can talk with you privately.”

4.5. If You Sense the Situation Is Serious

If a seafarer shows marked emotional distress, or hints at a threat to themselves or others — inform the coordinator at the seafarers’ centre or the responsible IMWIRSA coordinator immediately. Do not leave such signals unattended.

Your goal is not to “expose” or “fix” seafarers, but to be there. Sometimes a conversation with a visitor is the only human contact outside the working hierarchy. Simply be someone who sees, listens, and respects.

Section 5. Ship Types and Behaviour on Board

The figures below on size, crew numbers, and flag position are indicative and provided for the visitor’s general orientation — exact details should always be confirmed with the coordinator or on board.

Container Ship

Modern container ships are giants of maritime logistics, 150 to 400 metres long, capable of carrying up to 24,000 TEU (containers). Crews typically number 20–28, including officers and ratings.

The flag flies at the stern — usually on the aft superstructure or a mast behind the bridge. Container ships run to tight schedules; crews often face a fast pace of work and limited rest time in port. Short port stays, intensive crew workload.

Tanker — Oil / Chemical / Gas

Strict safety rules, an escort is often required. Tankers carry liquid cargo — oil, gas, chemicals. Length ranges from 180 to 350 metres, crews of 22–30.

The flag is usually flown from a staff at the stern. Tanker fleets are considered among the most technically demanding: strict safety measures, gas and pressure monitoring, higher requirements for personnel. Ship visitors should bear in mind access restrictions and safety measures when visiting such ships.

Bulk Carrier

Long voyages, the crew may be tired, limited shore leave. Bulk carriers transport dry bulk cargo — coal, grain, ore. Average length 150–300 metres, crews typically 18–24.

The flag sits at the stern, on a staff behind the wheelhouse. These ships require constant monitoring of cargo balance and safety, and conditions on board often depend on hold condition and weather. The work is physically demanding, especially during loading and discharge.

Ro-Ro / Car Carrier

Frequent port calls, a multinational crew, a demanding schedule. These ships carry cars and other wheeled cargo. Length 150–250 metres, crew 18–25.

The flag is at the stern or on the upper deck of the superstructure. The interior is filled with steel decks and ramps, creating a distinctive acoustics and microclimate. The crew works in an enclosed space, often without access to daylight — an important factor when assessing seafarers' psychological state.

Cruise / Passenger Ship

A large crew, limited access for visitors. Cruise ships can exceed 300 metres in length, with crews of 600 to 2,000 depending on capacity and class.

The flag is at the stern and on the upper deck, near the mast. The crew is multinational and divided by department (guest services, technical, deck, hospitality). Living conditions and comfort levels vary, but a heavy workload and long contracts create stress, particularly among service staff.

Reefer Ship

Reefer ships carry perishable goods — fruit, meat, fish. Length 100–150 metres, crew 16–22.

The flag is at the stern, near the superstructure. These ships often run short routes and call at ports more frequently than others. The crew is usually multinational, working at a fast pace with short port stays, which calls for visits to be organised quickly.

Fishing Vessel

Fishing vessels are among the most varied and demanding parts of the fleet, ranging from small coastal boats 15–30 metres long to large ocean trawlers up to 100–120 metres. Crews typically number 10 to 35, depending on the vessel's size and fishing method.

The flag is traditionally flown at the stern or on a mast near the superstructure. Work on fishing vessels is considered among the hardest in the maritime industry: crews often work in extreme weather, with minimal sleep and limited access to medical or psychological help. Space on board is tight, conditions noisy and damp, and the work schedule intensive, without fixed rest periods.

Despite the hardships, seafarers on such vessels typically form a close-knit crew built on mutual support.

Important legal point: the MLC-2006 does not apply to fishing vessels — their labour is governed by a separate instrument, ILO Convention No. 188 on Work in Fishing (C188). When working with fishing-vessel crews, a visitor applies C188 and the applicable national law, and does not rely on the MLC-2006 as the applicable legal basis (see Section 7 and “Sources” for more detail).

Tugboat

Tugboats are comparatively small vessels, 25–40 metres long, with crews of 6 to 10. They manoeuvre larger ships in ports and anchorages, and take part in rescue and emergency operations.

The flag is mounted on a stern staff or mast. Despite their small size, tugs are high-powered vessels, and working on one demands attentiveness, coordination, and physical fitness. Ship visitors should bear in mind that tug crews often work in shifts and live in cramped, noisy conditions.

Having met the different types of ships, it is worth remembering: behind every steel hull is a living crew, with its own history and its own share of hardship and joy at sea.

A container ship, a fishing vessel, a tanker, or a passenger liner — all differ in size, purpose, and working conditions, but seafarers share one thing in common: enormous responsibility, isolation from loved ones, and

daily physical and emotional strain. A ship visitor should approach every ship with an awareness of these differences.

Before a Visit, It Is Important To:

- Note the ship's type and the specific nature of the crew's work, in order to pitch the tone of the conversation correctly.
- Pay attention to small details — facial expressions, tone of voice, the atmosphere in the mess room. Sometimes it is these details that reveal how the crew is really doing.
- Be flexible and respectful: if the crew is tired, don't draw the conversation out; if they are open, give them the chance to talk.
- Do not judge by appearance or nationality — anyone on board may be carrying their own burden, and the visitor's task is not to judge but to understand and support.

General Rules of Conduct On Board, Regardless of Ship Type

- Follow the crew's instructions and the ship's rules.
- Do not go out on deck without permission.
- Use personal protective equipment (helmet, vest, closed-toe footwear) where required.
- Do not take photographs without consent.
- Maintain confidentiality.

Tips for Visitors

- If shore leave is not possible, offer help through the seafarers' centre.
- If in doubt, consult those in charge on board.

“Every ship is a world of its own, and every visit a small embassy of humanity on the waves.”

A ship is both a workplace and a home for its seafarers. Your courtesy and respect for the rules build the trust and comfort that make for a successful visit.

Section 6. Fundamentals of Cultural Sensitivity and Cross-Cultural Communication

Why Cultural Sensitivity Matters

- Seafarers come from many different countries and cultures.
- Respecting traditions and customs helps build a trusting connection.
- Non-verbal signals (gestures, expressions) can carry different meanings across cultures.

Key Principles of Cross-Cultural Communication

- Be open and tolerant of differences.
- Avoid stereotypes and bias.
- Listen attentively and show respect for the other person's views.
- Use simple language where needed, and avoid complex terminology.
- Show respect for religious and cultural particularities.

Practical Tips

- Ask questions to understand seafarers' cultural background.
- Don't impose your own views or rush the conversation.
- Remember that a smile and warmth are a universal language.
- If something is unclear, it is better to ask than to assume.

Section 7. Seafarers' Rights Under the MLC-2006 and C188

Full title of the convention: Maritime Labour Convention, 2006, as amended (MLC, 2006) — the ILO's 2006 convention on labour in maritime shipping, as subsequently amended. The 2022 amendments entered into force on 23 December 2024 and, among other things, expanded seafarers' right to social connectivity (access to the internet and contact with shore), clarified requirements for the quality of food and drinking water, and strengthened states' obligations regarding the repatriation of abandoned crews.

Core Seafarers' Rights (MLC-2006)

- The right to fair terms of employment and rest.
- The right to safe and healthy working conditions.
- The right to timely payment of wages.
- The right to medical care and social protection.
- The right to social connectivity, including access to means of communication and the internet in line with applicable requirements, and to shore leave, subject to operational requirements and port rules.
- The right to lodge complaints without victimisation; matters concerning termination of employment are governed by applicable law and the terms of the employment agreement.

Important: the MLC-2006 does not apply to fishing vessels. When working with the crews of such vessels, a visitor does not rely on the MLC-2006 as the applicable legal basis; ILO Convention No. 188 (C188) and the applicable national law must be taken into account.

The Ship Visitor's Role

- Making seafarers aware of their core rights.
- Informing them about local services and seafarers' centres where help is available.
- Referring seafarers to competent bodies where their rights have been violated — for example, the International Transport Workers' Federation (ITF), or port or state authorities.

Section 8. Personal Safety of the Visitor in Port and On Board

The International Port Security Regime (ISPS Code)

A significant part of the rules governing visitors' access to port areas and to ships is connected to the International Ship and Port Facility Security Code (ISPS Code) — a mandatory international security regime established by the IMO under the SOLAS Convention (Chapter XI-2). The ISPS Code establishes an international system for securing ships and port facilities. The specific procedure for admitting visitors is determined by the applicable national law, the port facility security plan, the ship security plan, and the rules of the relevant port or terminal. Within this system, elements of local procedure typically include:

- port and ship security levels and the corresponding restrictions;
- procedures for checking documents and escorting visitors;
- restricted-access zones and requirements for marking them;
- the need for prior clearance of the visit with the Port Facility Security Officer (PFSO) or the Ship Security Officer (SSO).

A visitor must comply without exception with the instructions of the port or ship security officer, even where these differ from the usual course of a visit.

Basic Safety Rules

- Report your visit to those responsible on the ship and at the seafarers' centre.
- Always carry your visitor identification.

- Do not visit a ship while fatigued, ill, or under the influence of alcohol or drugs.
- Follow health and safety rules on board.
- Avoid hazardous areas and working with dangerous substances without an escort.

Safety in Port

- Stay alert in crowded or unfamiliar areas.
- Do not leave personal belongings unattended.
- Use only official routes and transport.
- Avoid confrontation and do not get drawn into arguments.

Approaching the Ship

- Announce your arrival through your point of contact (agent or crew).
- Confirm permission to come up the gangway.
- Inspect the gangway — it should be secured, non-slip, lit, and fitted with a safety net.
- If the gangway is unsafe, or you feel unsafe, decline to board and inform the IMWIRSA coordinator.

On Board

- Always introduce yourself to the officer on watch and sign in if asked.
- Do not enter compartments without an escort.
- Do not enter the engine room, bridge, cargo areas, or crew accommodation without permission.
- Find out the location of emergency exits, life jackets, and the first-aid kit.
- Do not put your phone on loudspeaker, and do not photograph crew members without their consent.
- Do not accept parcels or cargo for safekeeping without prior agreement with the IMWIRSA coordinator.
- In the event of an alarm, follow the crew's instructions or leave the ship immediately.

What to Do in an Emergency

- Inform those responsible on board and the IMWIRSA coordinator.
- Keep the contact details of emergency services and fellow visitors to hand.
- Stay calm and follow instructions.
- If you feel threatened (by the crew, conditions, or technical factors) — end the visit immediately and go ashore.
- Inform the IMWIRSA coordinator and, if necessary, port security or the port authority.
- Prepare a brief report if the situation requires analysis or follow-up.

What Not to Do

- Consume food or drink without being invited.
- Bring alcohol, cigarettes, medication, or sharp objects.
- Discuss wages, complaints, or religious topics without cause.
- Stay on board longer than agreed with the officer on watch — the length of a visit depends on the ship's schedule, the crew's availability, and terminal requirements, not on a fixed time.
- Interfere in operational processes (mooring, cargo work, watchkeeping).
- Work as a visitor while fatigued, unwell, or under emotional stress.

A visitor has the right to end a visit at any time if they consider the conditions unsafe or contrary to the Ship Visitor Code. A visitor's safety takes priority over completing the visit.

After the Visit

- Give the IMWIRSA coordinator a brief report (using the checklist or verbally).
- Take time to recover, particularly after visiting a large or demanding ship.
- Where necessary, complete an anonymous incident feedback form.

Only anonymised information is included in the general report. Where providing assistance requires processing personal data, this is handled separately through the IMWIRSA coordinator, on a documented legal basis, in accordance with Section 9.

Remember: your safety is the foundation of a successful visit. You come in peace, but you are not obliged to put yourself at risk. Even a single visitor can change a seafarer's day or mood — what matters is that you return to the centre safely, ready to help again.

Section 9. Personal Data Protection (GDPR)

IMWIRSA is an organisation operating within the jurisdiction of the European Union. The processing of personal data carried out as part of IMWIRSA's activities within the European Union is conducted in accordance with the General Data Protection Regulation (Regulation (EU) 2016/679, GDPR) and applicable national law; when operating outside the EU, the law of the relevant country is also taken into account. The phrase “passing information to the coordinator to provide assistance” is not, by itself, a sufficient legal basis for processing personal data — the GDPR requires lawfulness, transparency, data minimisation, and a limited retention period.

9.1. What Data Counts as Personal in a Visitor's Report

A confidential report on a specific case may contain information about a seafarer's nationality, emotional state, complaints, and other people connected with the situation. Where a specific individual can be identified, this constitutes personal data. Information about health, religion, and trade union membership falls within special categories of personal data (Art. 9 GDPR) and requires heightened protection.

9.2. Core Principles for a Visitor Handling Data

- Record only the data genuinely necessary to provide assistance (the minimisation principle).
- Wherever possible, record information in anonymised form — without a name, position, or other details that would allow a specific person to be identified.
- Pass data only to the IMWIRSA coordinator or another authorised specialist — never through personal messaging apps, social media, or unsecured devices.
- Do not retain reports and records for longer than the period set by IMWIRSA's internal policy.
- Record special categories of data (health, religion, trade union membership) only where directly necessary, and where possible with the seafarer's consent.

9.3. Legal Basis for Processing Data

Before collecting and transferring personal data, IMWIRSA determines and documents the applicable legal basis in accordance with Article 6 GDPR, and, for special categories of data, the corresponding condition under Article 9 GDPR. Where processing is based on consent, that consent must be freely given, specific, informed, and capable of being withdrawn. In the event of a direct threat to life or health, information may be shared to the minimum extent necessary on the basis of protecting vital interests, where the conditions set out in the GDPR are met. A ship visitor does not determine the legal basis themselves, but acts in accordance with IMWIRSA's approved policy.

9.4. Access to Data

Access to visitors' reports is limited to the IMWIRSA programme coordinator and those directly involved in providing assistance in a specific case. Sharing data outside the programme (for example, with a shipowner, agent, or third-party organisation) requires a separate legal basis and, as a rule, the seafarer's consent.

Section 10. Crisis Situations and the Escalation Procedure (Safeguarding)

This section sets out in detail the principles laid down in Section 5 of the Code, and gives the visitor a clear course of action for the most serious situations.

10.1. Situations Requiring Immediate Escalation

- Violence and sexual harassment.
- A threat of suicide or self-harm.
- Signs of human trafficking or forced labour.
- The presence on board of a person below the applicable minimum age, or signs that a seafarer under 18 is engaged in prohibited hazardous work or unlawful night work, or is subject to violence or exploitation.
- Retaliation against a seafarer after they have raised a complaint.
- A situation in which the master or a senior officer may themselves be the source of the threat or the violation.

10.2. The Escalation Route

The general course of action on identifying signs of a serious problem:

- 1) Immediate danger to life — call the emergency services of the port or country.
- 2) Where it is safe and appropriate — inform the person responsible on the ship, except where that person may themselves be implicated in the threat (see below).
- 3) Inform the IMWIRSA coordinator immediately — by phone or another agreed channel.
- 4) Where necessary — contact a specialised support service, the ITF, or port or state authorities.

Important: where there is reason to believe the master or a senior officer is implicated in the violation, information is not passed to ship's command — the visitor acts through the IMWIRSA coordinator and, if necessary, directly through the ITF or port authorities.

10.3. The Limits of the Visitor's Role in a Crisis

- A visitor does not conduct an investigation or determine guilt.
- A visitor does not take on the role of a psychologist, a rescuer, or a mediator between parties to a conflict.
- The visitor's task is to recognise the signal, provide initial support, and safely pass on the information through the established route.

Glossary of Maritime Terms for Ship Visitors

General Maritime Terms

Vessel / Ship — a seagoing craft designed to carry cargo or passengers.

Crew — everyone officially working on board a ship.

Master — the ship's commander, who bears full responsibility for the ship, crew, and operations on board.

Chief Officer / Chief Mate — the master's deputy for deck operations, responsible for safety, cargo operations, and part of the crew.

Chief Engineer — responsible for the ship's technical condition and its engines.

Ratings — crew members who are not part of the officer corps; this includes able seamen, motormen, and other rating-level specialists.

Life on Board

Cabin — a seafarer's living quarters on board.

Galley — the ship's kitchen.

Mess Room — the place where the crew eats.

Bridge — the ship's command centre, from which navigation is carried out.

Engine Room — the technical area housing the engines and machinery.

Navigation and Ship Movement

Deck — an open or enclosed horizontal surface of the ship on which the crew moves about.

Gangway — a ladder or ramp for boarding or leaving the ship.

Mooring — the process of securing a ship to a berth with lines.

Berth / Quay / Dock — the place in a port where a ship is moored.

Boatswain / Bosun — the senior rating who directs deck work.

Duties and Watches on Board

Watch — a work shift. The crew stands round-the-clock watches (e.g. 00:00–04:00).

Officer of the Watch / Officer on Duty — the person responsible for keeping watch and for the ship's safety within their duties.

Log Book — the official document in which voyage, weather, incident, and other data are recorded.

Visitor's Log Book — the log in which every visitor who comes on board is recorded.

Safety and Security

PPE (Personal Protective Equipment) — protective gear (helmet, vest, goggles, etc.).

Safety Briefing — a safety induction for visitors or new crew members.

Emergency Drill — a training exercise or rehearsal for an emergency.

Evacuation Plan — the plan for evacuating the ship.

Restricted Area — an access-controlled zone (crew only, or by special permission).

Psychological and Social Wellbeing

Isolation — the sense of social detachment characteristic of long voyages.

Contract — a seafarer's employment agreement, typically for 6–9 months.

Ship Agent — the shipowner's representative in port, who handles legal and logistical matters.

Crew Change — the turnover of ship's personnel (in port or at anchor).

Port Call — a ship's arrival at, and stay in, a port.

Religious and Cultural Terms

Stella Maris / Apostleship of the Sea — the Catholic mission for seafarers' welfare.

International Seamen's Mission / Seafarers' Centre — a shore-based support centre for seafarers (which may be interdenominational).

ICMA (International Christian Maritime Association) — an international network of religious and secular organisations supporting seafarers.

Labour and Legal Terms

MLC-2006 (Maritime Labour Convention) — the maritime labour convention setting out seafarers' rights.

Flag State — the country whose flag a ship flies, which determines the jurisdiction and law applicable to the ship.

ITF (International Transport Workers' Federation) — an international federation of transport workers that protects seafarers' rights.

Port State Control (PSC) — inspection of a ship in port by the authorities of the country of call.

Welfare Support — the full range of assistance available to seafarers: legal, medical, emotional, and spiritual.

Terms Relating to Visits

Ship Visit — a visit to a ship by a representative of a seafarers' centre or charitable organisation.

Pastoral Care — spiritual and emotional support provided by a visitor; not a substitute for professional psychological help.

Confidentiality — a visitor's obligation not to disclose a seafarer's personal information without their consent.

Sources and Regulatory Framework

This guide draws on the following international instruments and recognised professional practice. Where the text of this guide and a primary source diverge, the primary source takes precedence.

Maritime Labour Convention, 2006, as amended (MLC, 2006) — consolidated text incorporating subsequent amendments, including the 2022 amendments (in force from 23 December 2024). [ilo.org](https://www.ilo.org)

ILO Work in Fishing Convention, 2007 (No. 188, C188) — governs labour on fishing vessels not covered by the MLC-2006. [ilo.org](https://www.ilo.org)

International Ship and Port Facility Security (ISPS) Code — adopted under the SOLAS Convention, Chapter XI-2, IMO. [imo.org](https://www.imo.org)

Regulation (EU) 2016/679 (General Data Protection Regulation, GDPR). eur-lex.europa.eu

ICMA / Merchant Navy Welfare Board — the “Ship Welfare Visitors Course”, used as a reference point for the structure of this material. mnwb.org

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